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Economic
and Social
Research Council

The Development of Moral Concern for Animals Across Cultures



Humans are viewed as
having high moral status



Animals are viewed as
having lower moral status



Humans care about the well-being of some animals



★ Species Membership

★ Moral Hierarchy

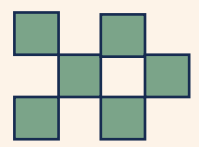
Cognitive Abilities

Sentience

★ Relational Characteristics

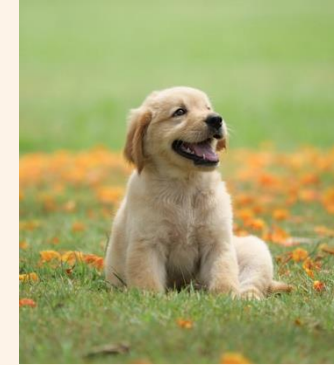
Whilst endorsing harm to others





Speciesism

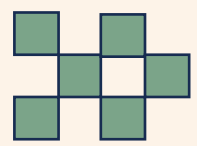
Assignment of different moral status based ***solely*** on ***species membership***



- Humans hold greater inherent value than members of other species
- Differential treatment of species that possess similar emotional and mental capacities is morally justifiable

A very robust tendency in ***adults***





What Next?

Animals are valued less than humans. But is this true across:

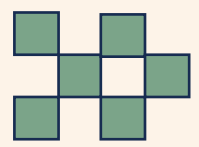
- Development
- Cultures
- Animal species

The way humans think about and assign moral value to other animals is often based on ***relational*** properties

This is ***learned*** within a *cultural*, social and historic context

Our developing ideas about moral value of other beings may be based on ***cultural-dependent socialization***





Key Aims

Primary focus in the ***developmental trajectories*** of moral thinking towards animals

3 main questions:

- *What is the shape of the developmental trajectory?* ←
- *Do children, adolescents and adults differ?*
- *What is the developmental window of greatest change?*



Moral Status

Eating Animals

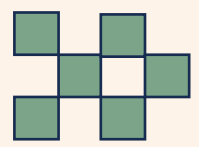
Reasoning

Speciesism Scale

Categorization

Food-Systems

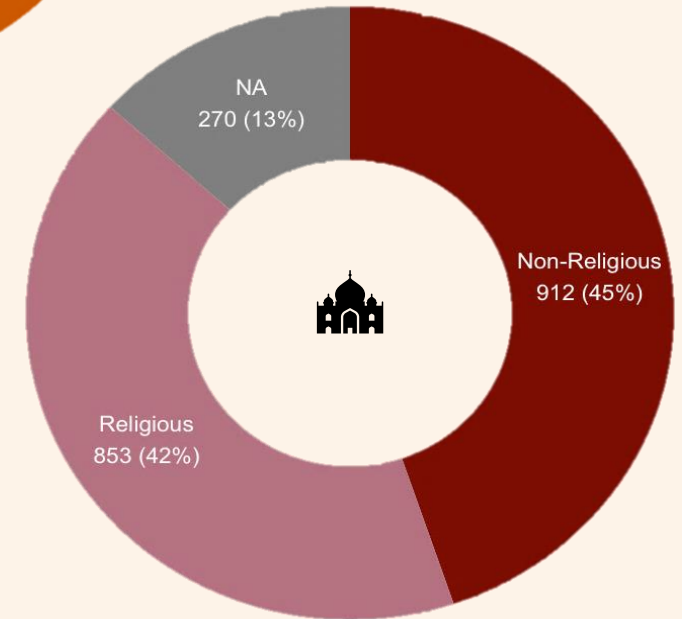
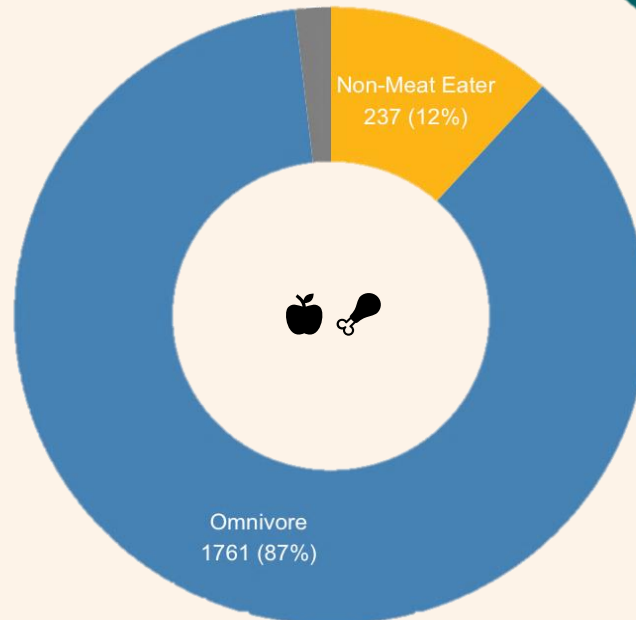
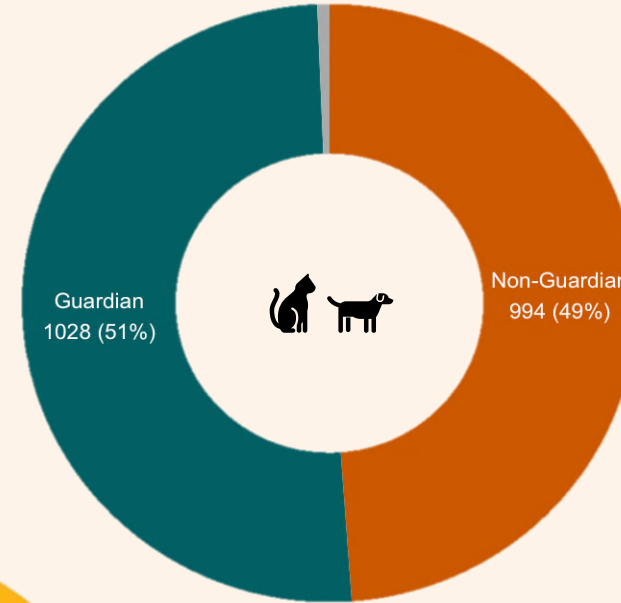
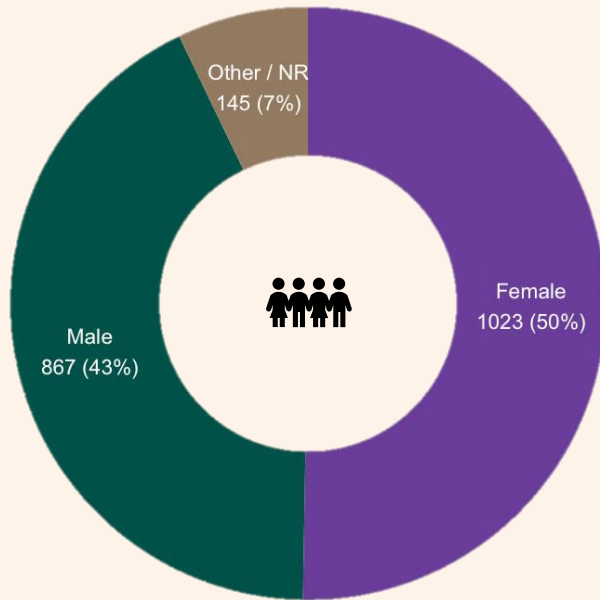
Knowledge of Treatment

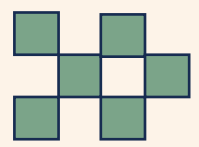


Sample



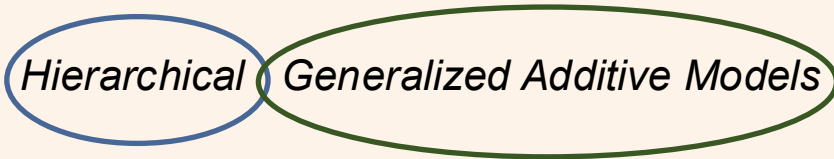
- **2035** participants (post exclusion criteria)
 - Age range --> 8-22 years
 - Passed attention checks





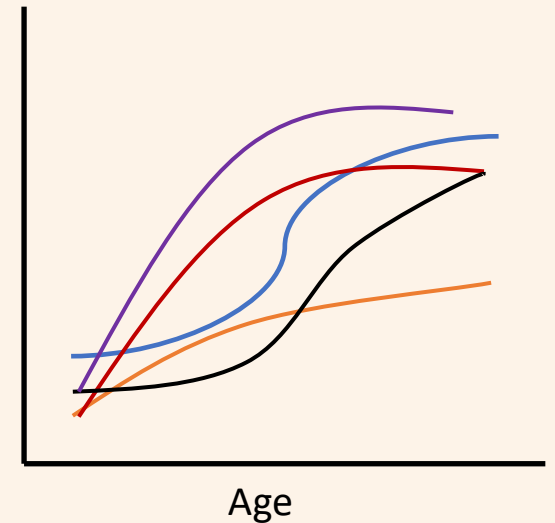
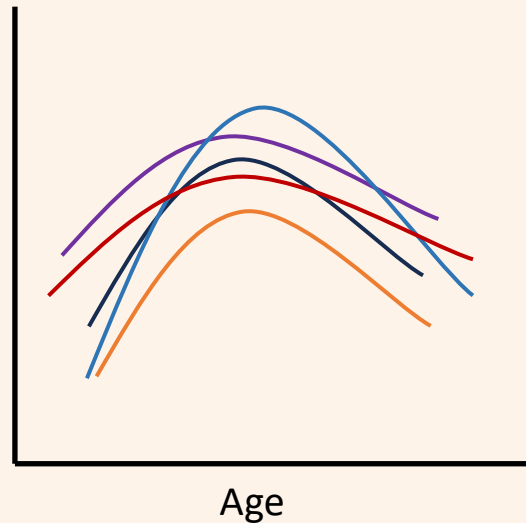
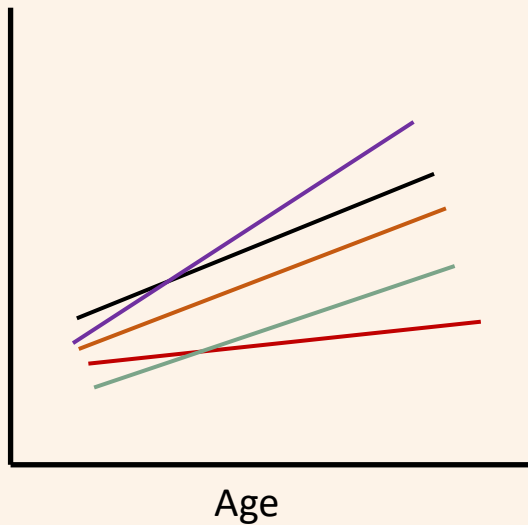
Analysis

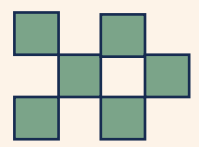
Data analyzed using a Bayesian models



because some DV's involve
multiple items per participant

Allows modeling of non-linear relationships (and the
shape can vary between the different countries)





Ascription of Moral Status

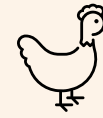
“How well should humans treat [*species*]”



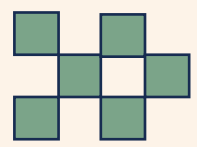
Not well at
all



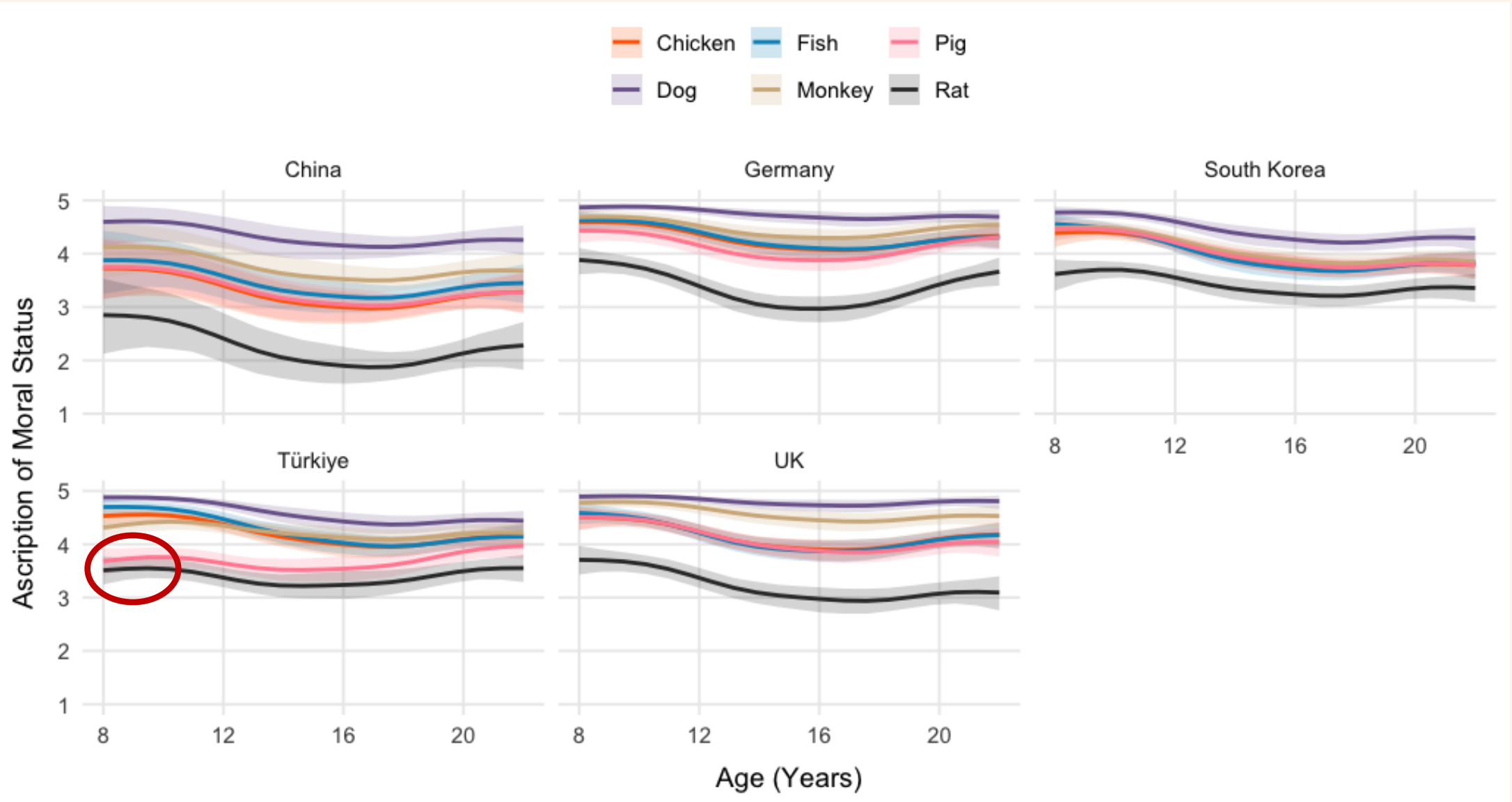
Extremely
well

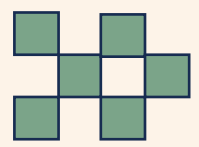


“Why do you think people should treat [*dogs/pigs*] in this way”



Ascription of Moral Status



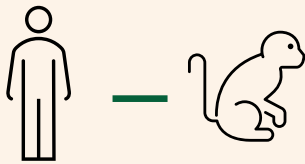


Ascription of Moral Status

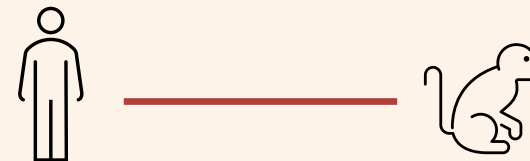
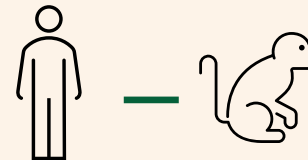
Also looked at judgements of the *relative* status of animals compared to humans

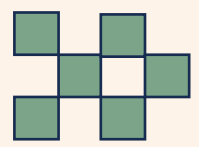
- In general – the moral status distance between humans and animals increased with age
- But not all species were devalued to the same degree, and some cross-cultural differences

Children



Adolescents & Adults





Moral Status - Reasoning

Relational Characteristics

Social Role --> “because they are pets” “they are used for meat”

Social Traits --> “dogs are loyal and friendly” “people see them as dirty”

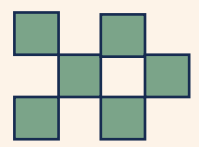
Intrinsic Characteristics

Sentience --> “they have complex emotions” “they experience pain”

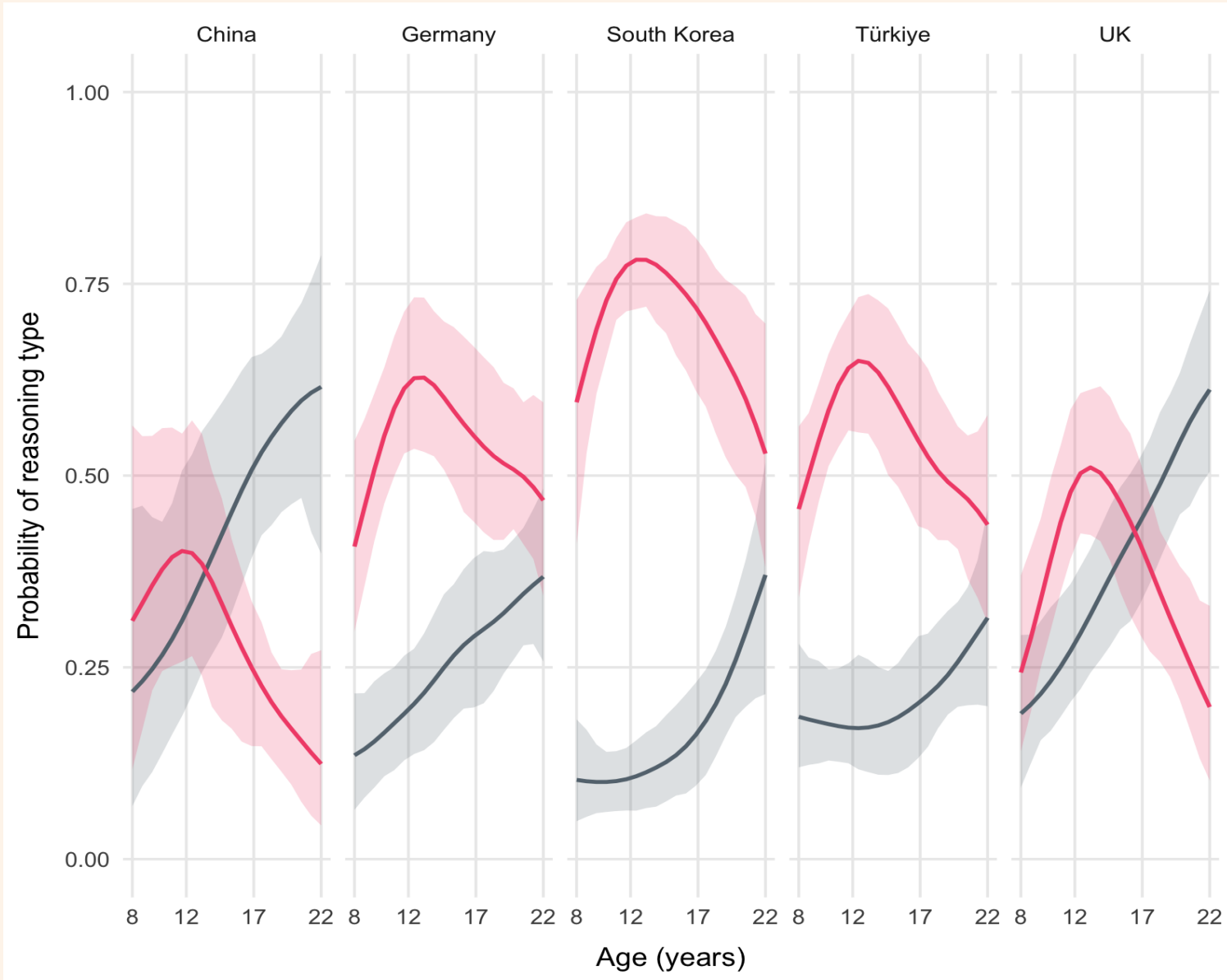
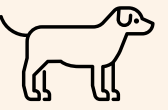
Agency --> “dogs are one of the smartest animals”

Life --> “because they are a living animal”

Physical Properties --> “they are beautiful, cute and fluffy”

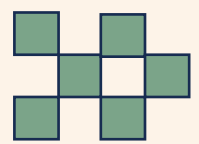


Dog -- Reasoning

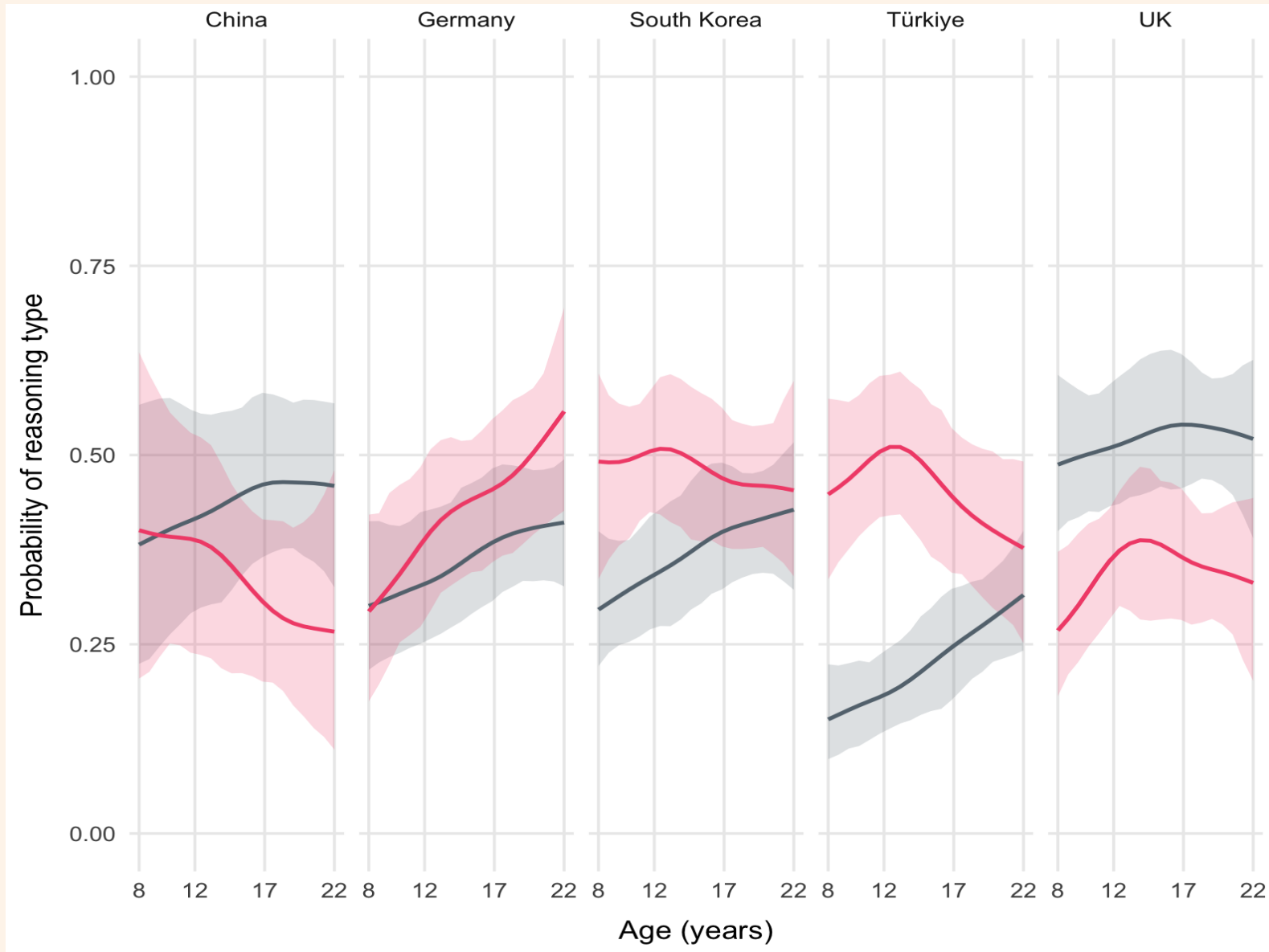
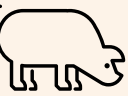


Relational Characteristics

Intrinsic Characteristics

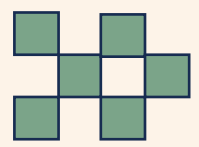


Pig -- Reasoning



Relational Characteristics

Intrinsic Characteristics



Moral Evaluation of Eating Animals

“Do you think it’s okay to eat animals?”



Not Okay

Okay

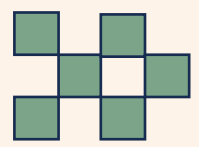
“How okay or not okay is it to eat animals?”



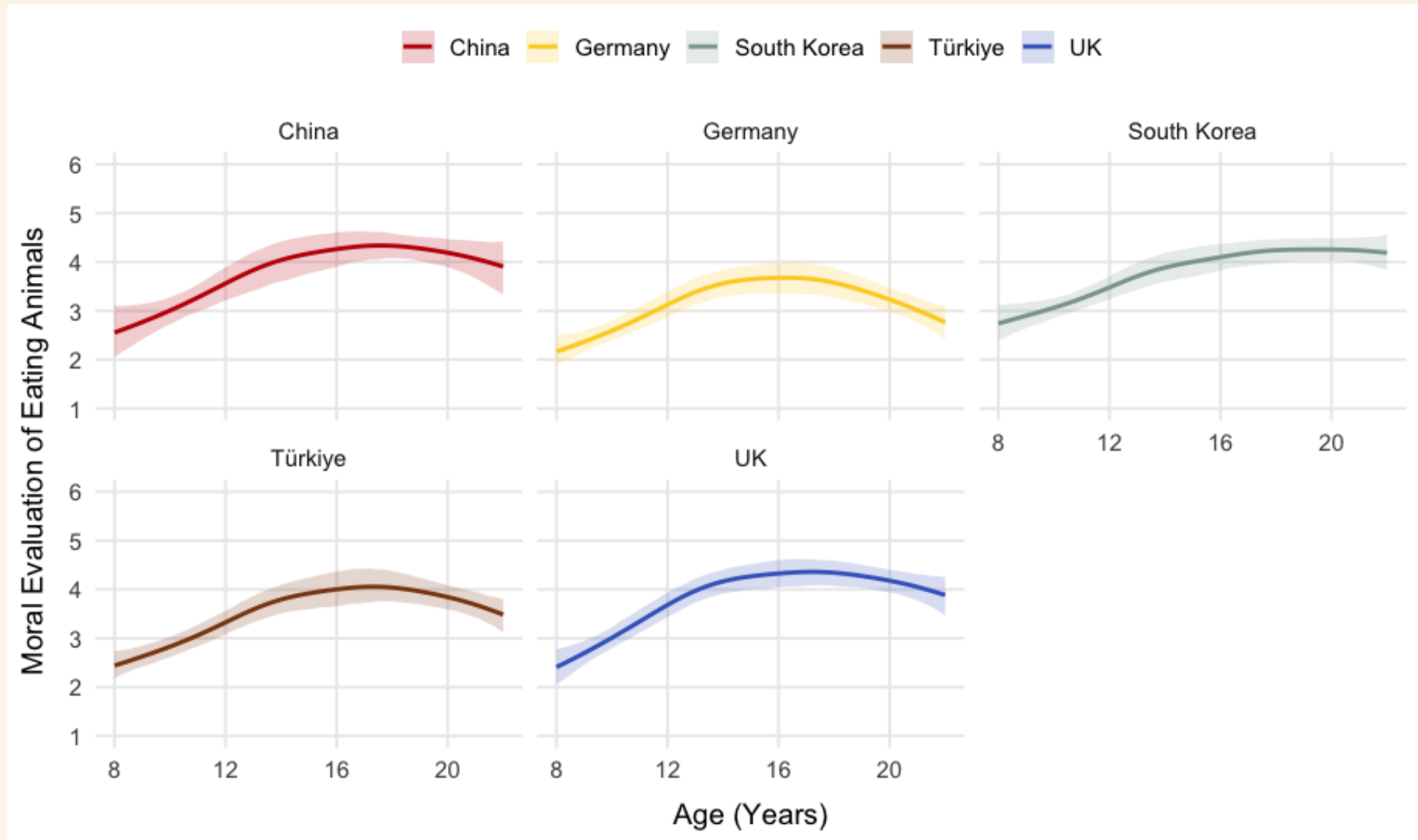
Really Not Okay

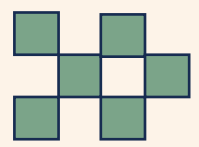
Really Okay

”Why do you think it’s okay or not okay to eat animals”



Moral Evaluation of Eating Animals





Eating Animals - Reasoning

Moral

Animal Rights--> “animals deserve equal rights”

Animal Welfare --> “They must be in a lot of pain”

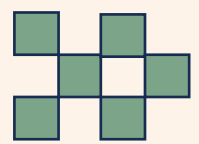
4 Ns of Meat-Eating

Natural --> “humans are biologically omnivorous” “It’s the food chain”

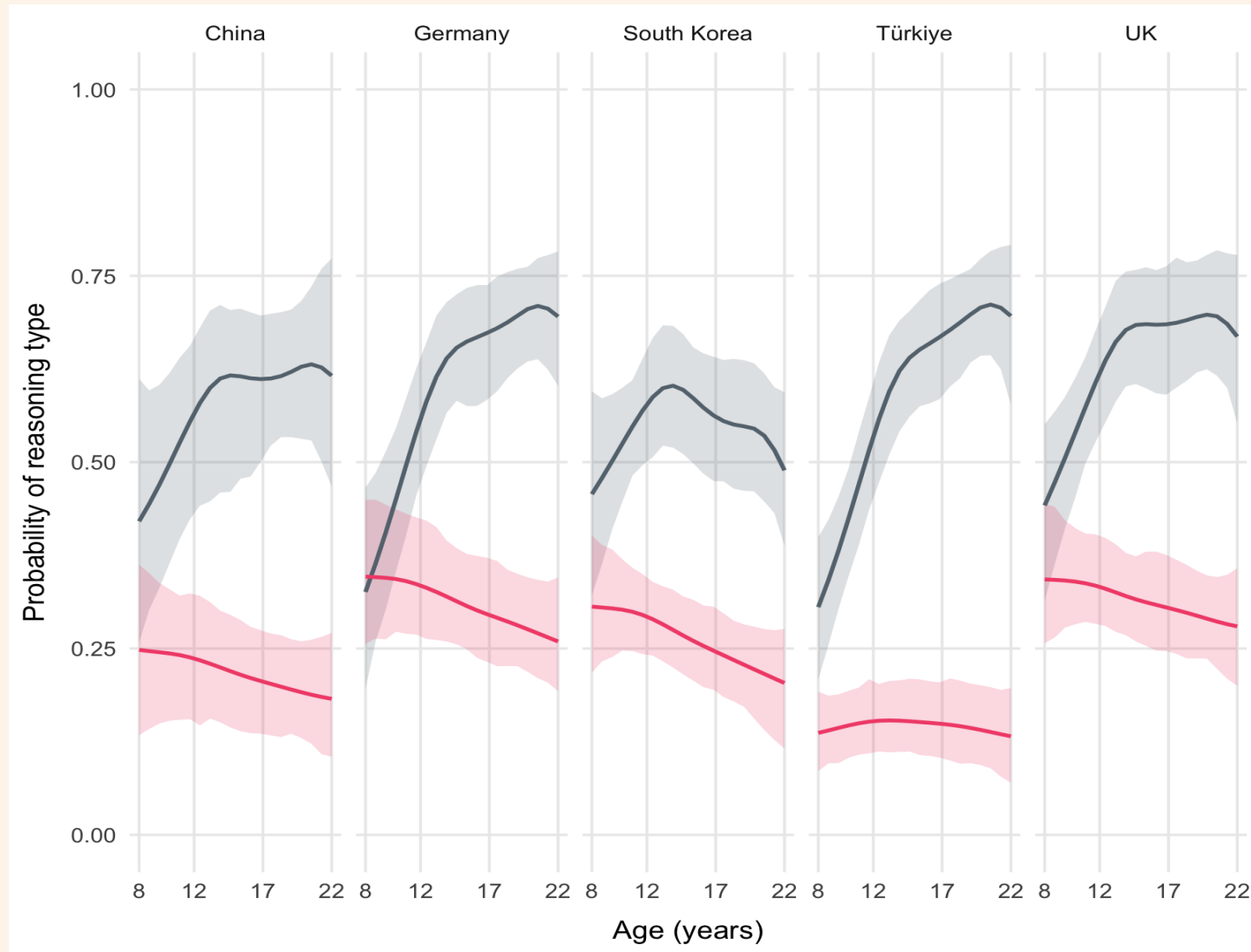
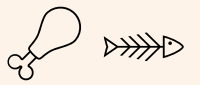
Necessary --> “We need to eat animals for nutrients and to stay healthy”

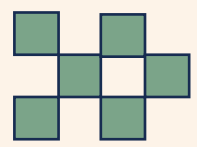
Normal --> “Society says it’s okay” “It is culturally accepted”

Nice--> “It tastes good”



Eating Animals - Reasoning





Sum Up

Evidence of general '**moral constriction**' with age

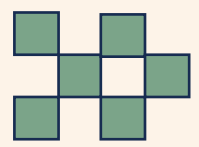
- Decreasing moral status ascribed to animals
- Increasing belief that it is morally acceptable to eat animal



The target, timing and magnitude of moral status downgrading shows some cultural nuance

Age and cultural nuance in **moral reasoning**

- Relational characteristics and 4 Ns of meat-eating increasingly prominent



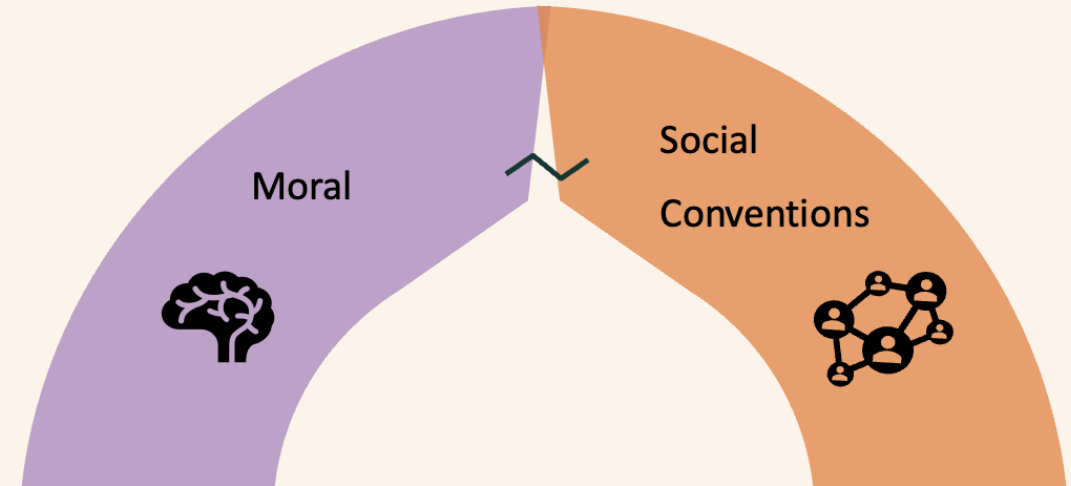
Why? How?

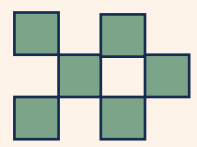
Developmentally

- Increasing importance of social/cultural norms

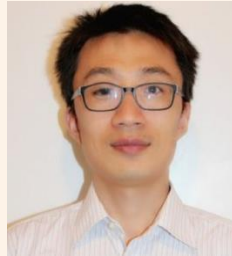
Cross-Culture

- Children **everywhere** share the same **predisposition** to acquire cultural knowledge – but learn the norms and values of their **specific** culture/community
- **Salience** of norms dictate developmental trajectories





Thank you



Alexander G Carter

Feel free to write for future collaboration:

ac1037@exeter.ac.uk



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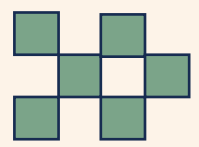
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Extras – Speciesism Scale

Speciesism Scale

‘Animals are worth less than people’

‘People can use animals in any way they want’

‘It is okay to keep animals in the circus for people to watch’

‘It is okay to buy and sell animals like toys or clothes’

‘Monkeys should be looked after so people aren’t allowed to hurt them’

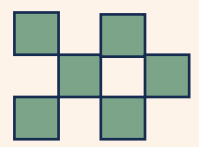
‘It is okay to try new medicine on animals that we would not try on people’



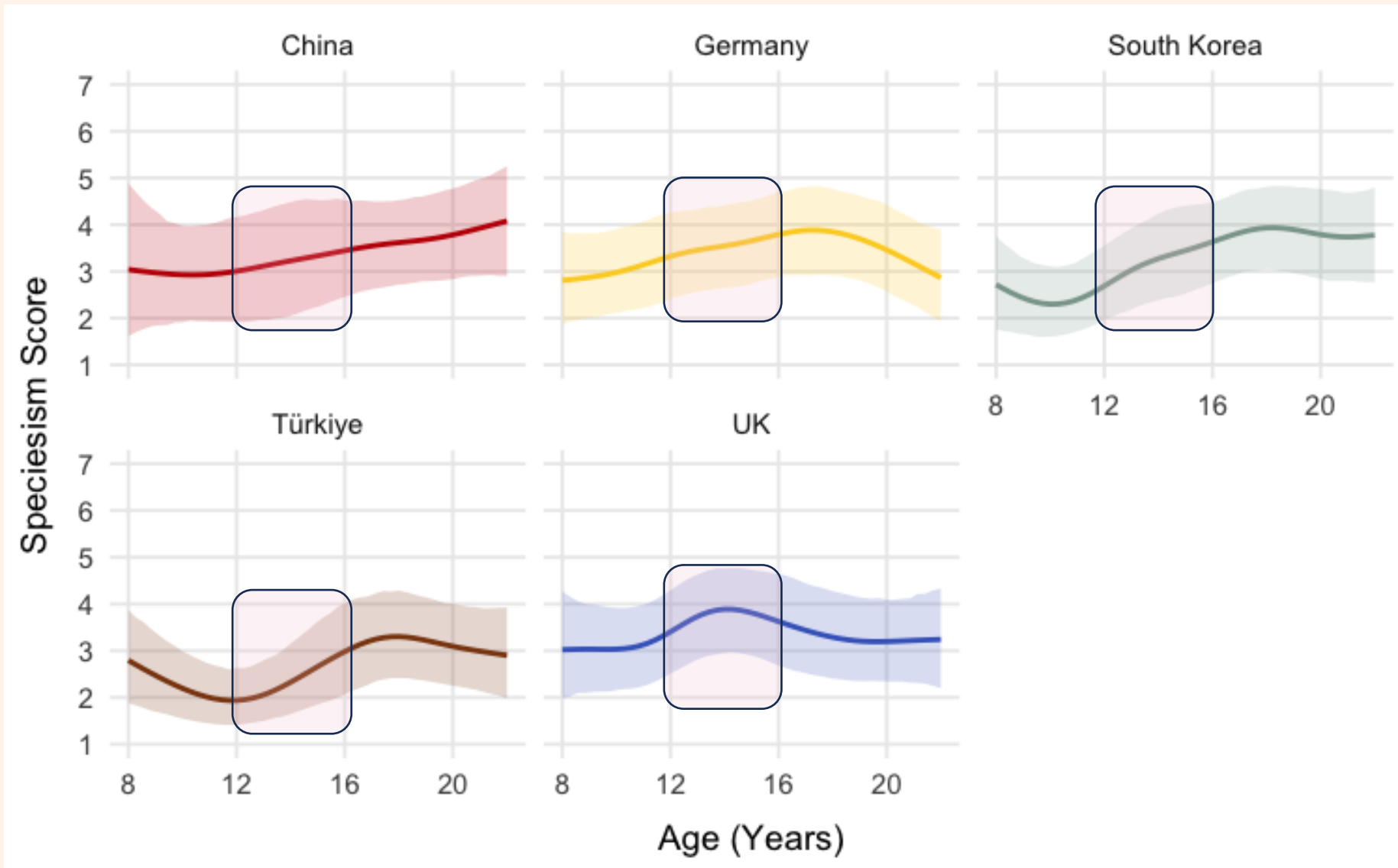
No,
definitely not

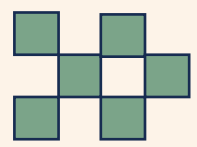
Yes, definitely

Higher scores = more driven by species membership
in terms of who they feel concern for



Extras – Speciesism Scale

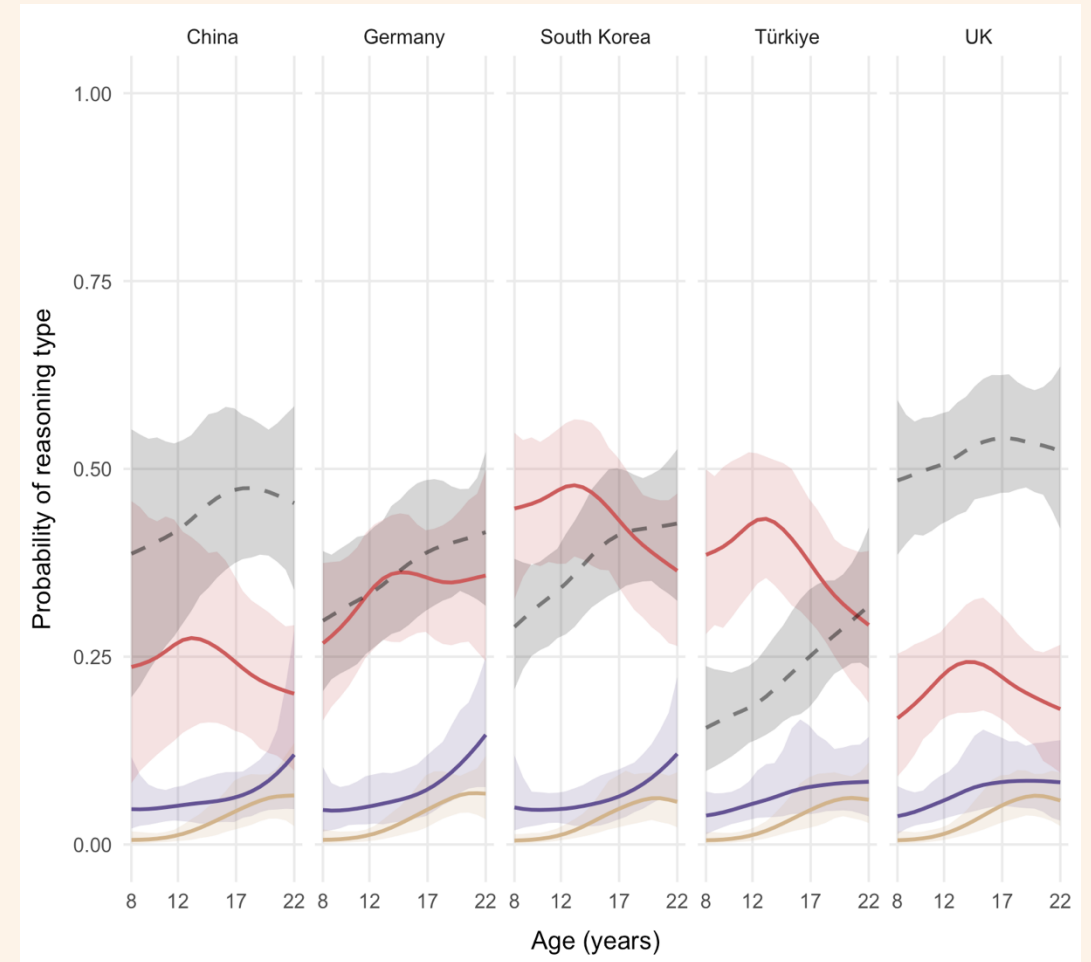
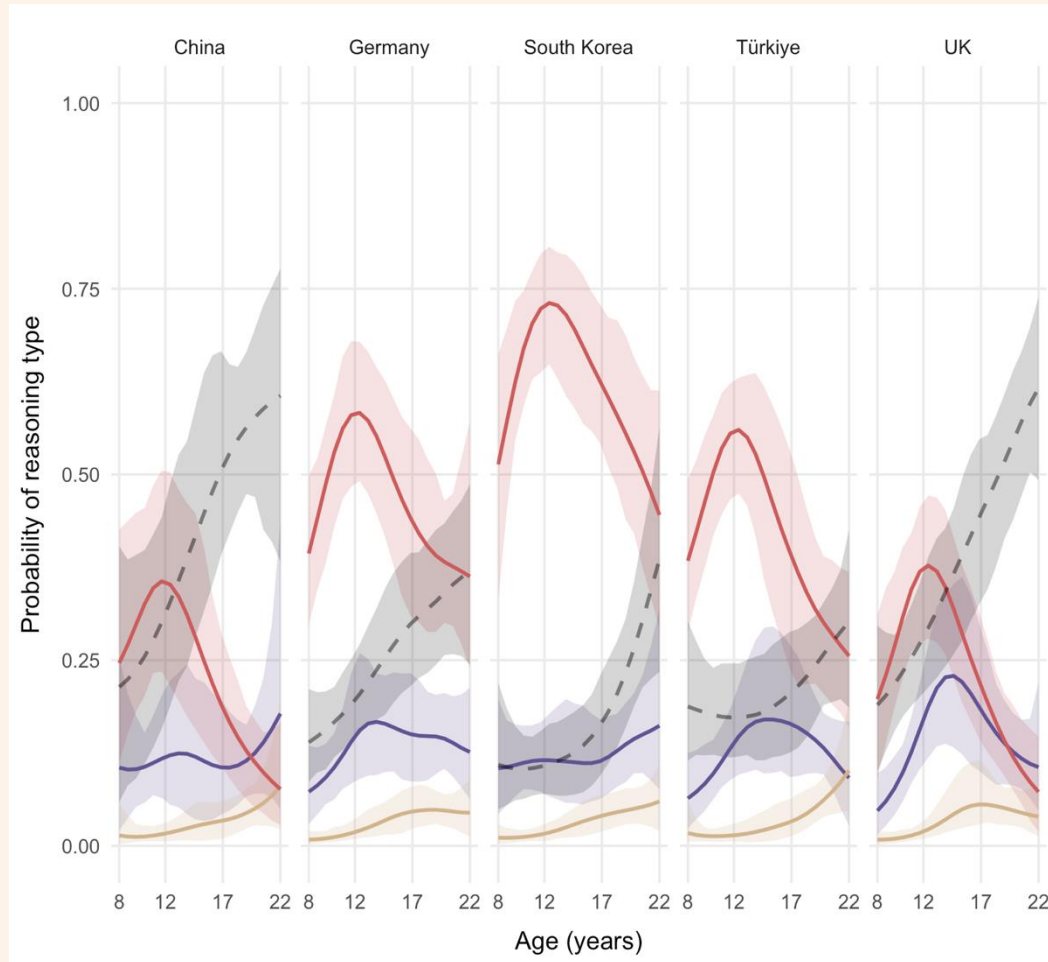
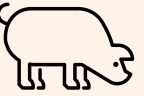


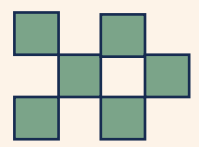


Extras – Moral Status - Breakdown of Intrinsic

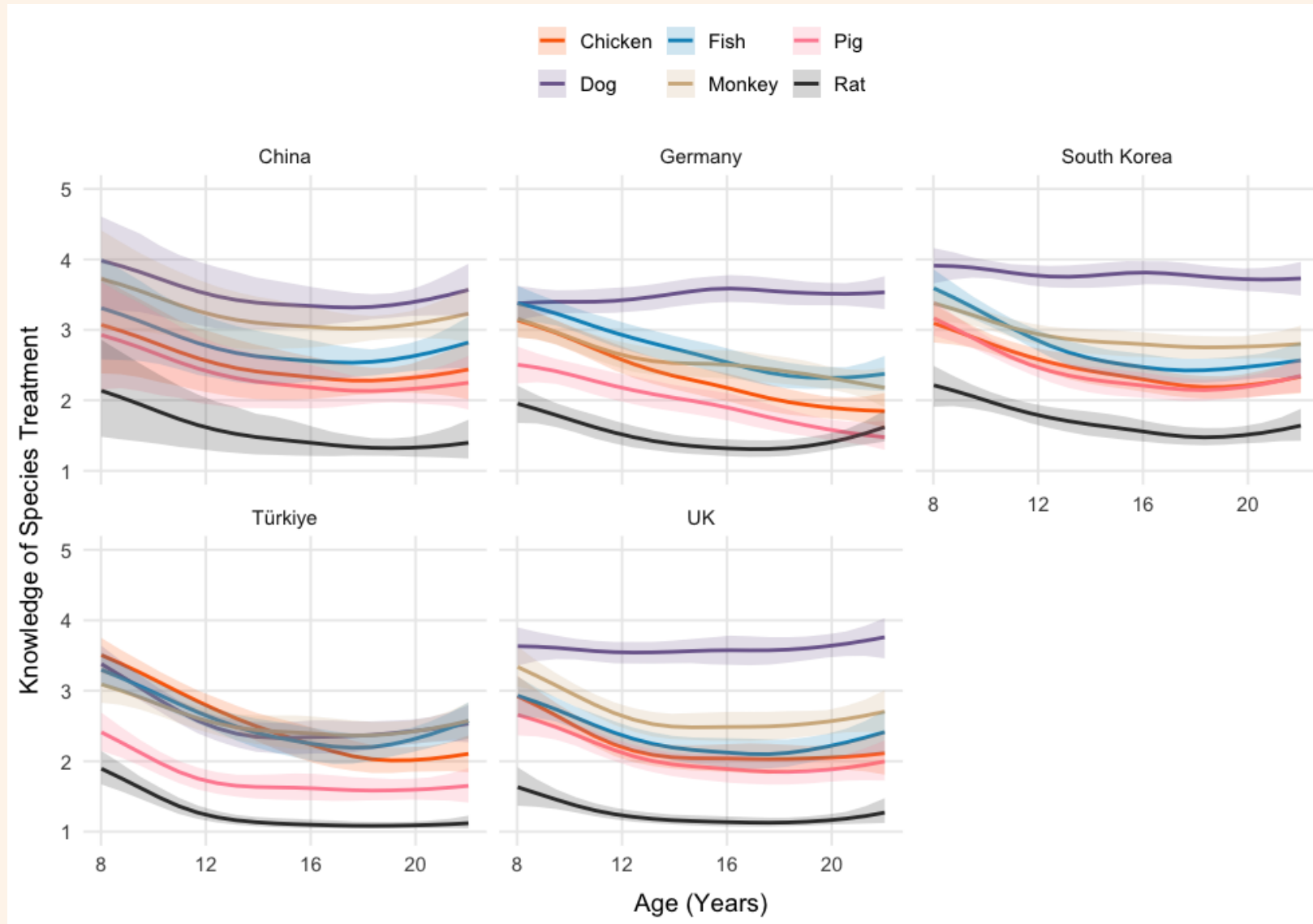


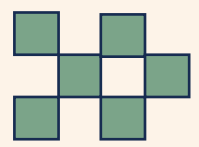
■ Sentence ■ Agency ■ Life ■ Relational Characteristics



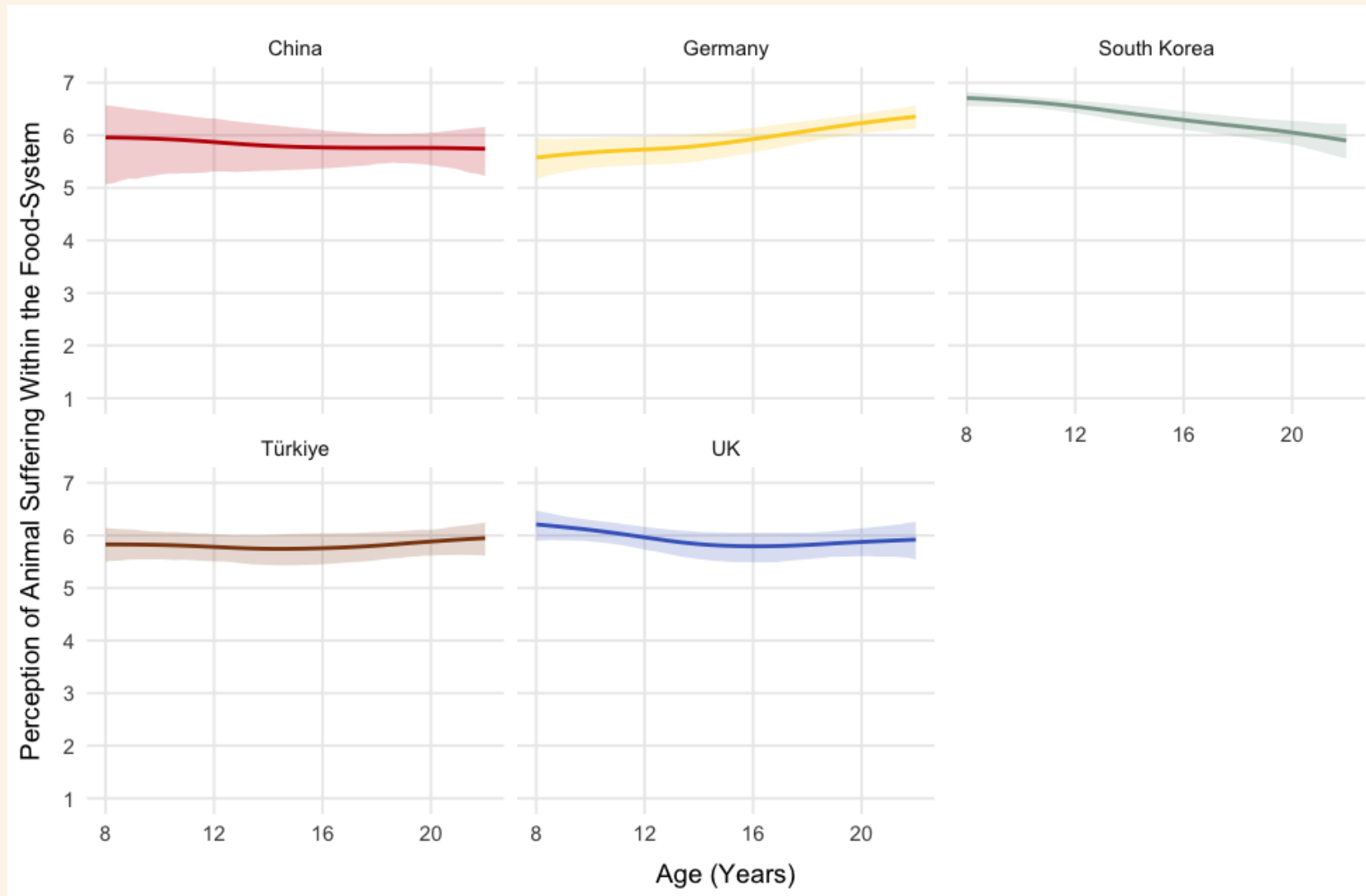


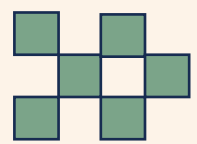
Extras – Knowledge of Species Treatment





Extras – Food-Systems

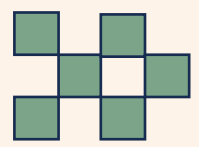




Extras – Categorization

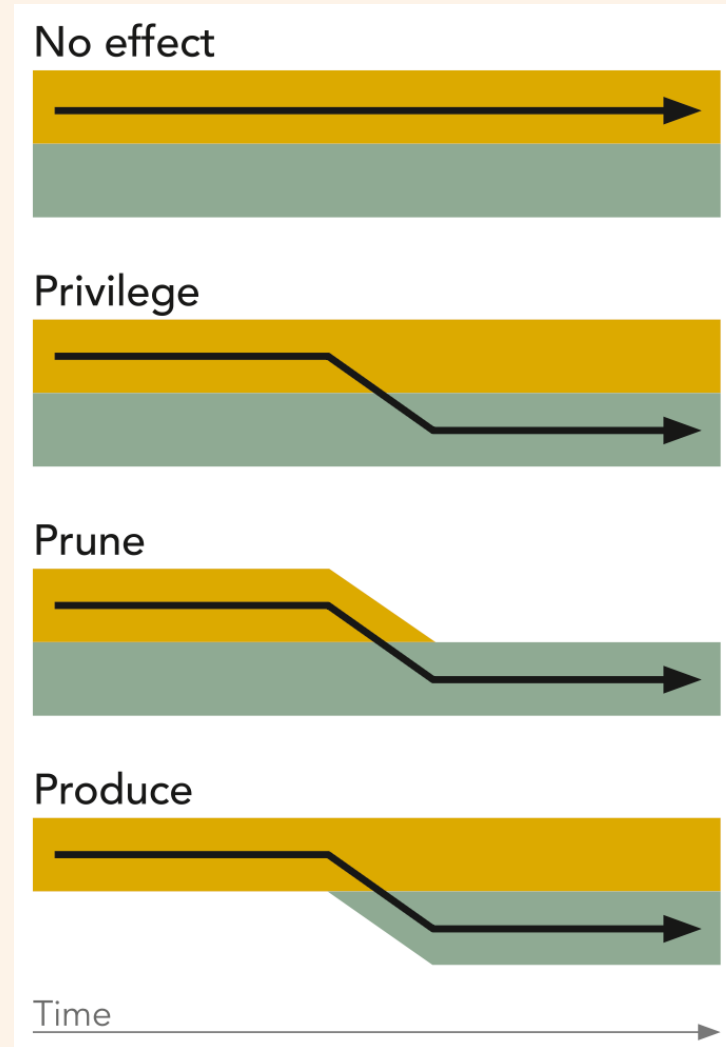
	Chicken	Fish	Pig	Dog	Monkey	Rat
All Sample	94.8	94.9	79.2	7.2	3.5	3.6
Children	93.2	93.5	79.6	8.1	5.2	4.4
Adolescents	95.9	96.6	78.5	7.6	2.9	3.7
Adults	95.5	95.2	79.5	5.9	2.0	2.6

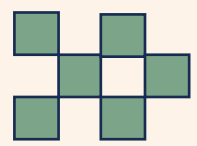
Table X | Percentage of participants who categorised animal species as ‘food’ animals. Results are collapsed across all countries and shown for children, adolescents, adults separately.



Extras – Culture pathways

Pathways – “how culture can shape cognition”





Türkiye

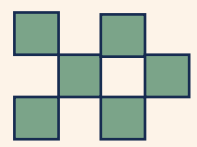
“Dogs have a long history in Türkiye as **protectors** (shepherd dogs), loyal **companions**, or communal street animals.

When it comes to pigs, Unlike cows or sheep, pigs have **no role** in traditional Turkish life, they are not a source of food, labour, or companionship”

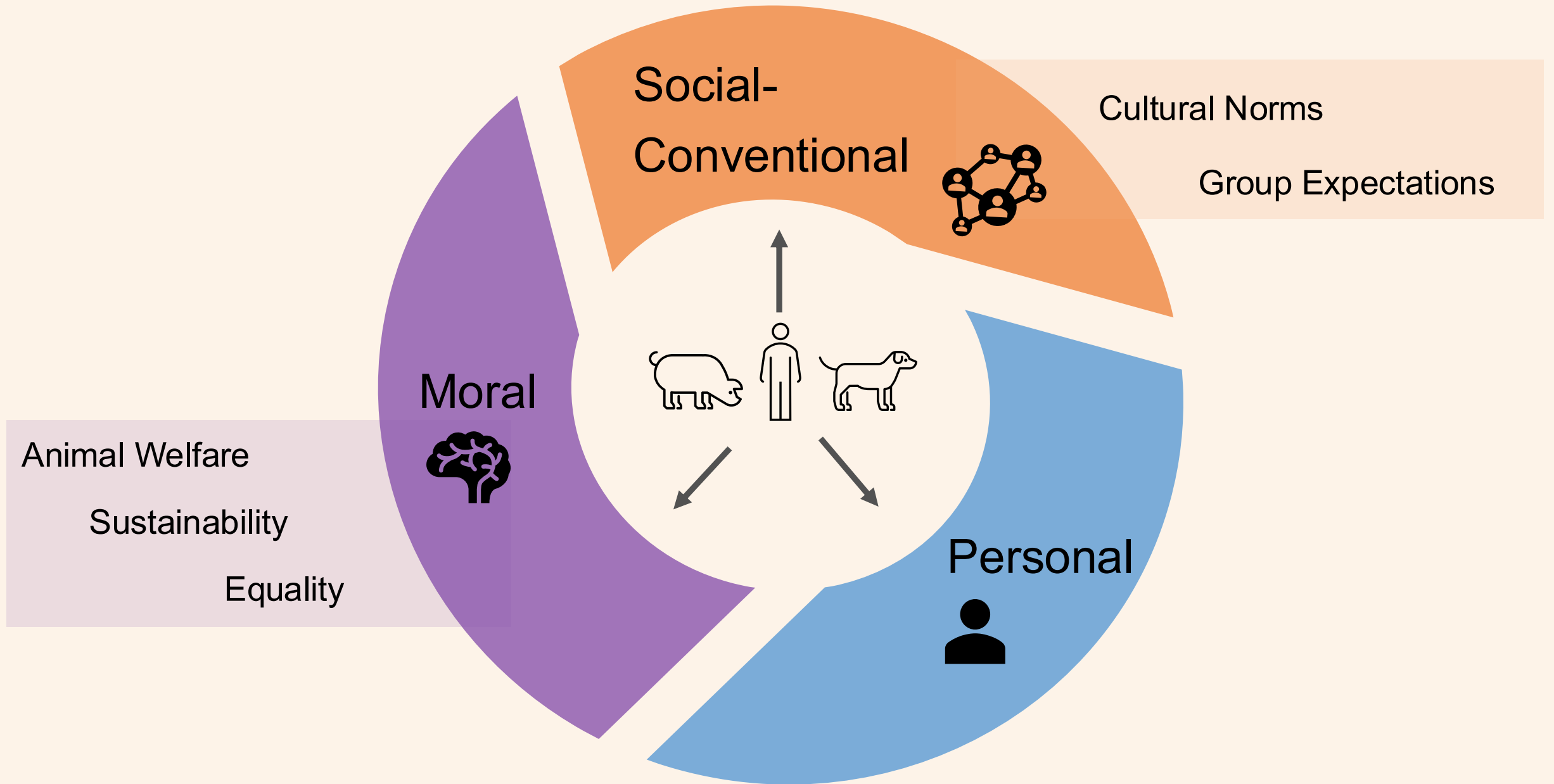


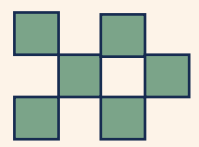
Therefore, the pig is often categorized similarly to a **pest** (like a rat) because it is seen as an outgroup entity that is both religiously forbidden (*haram*) and physically repulsive.

This combination of **lack of utility** and **ritualized disgust** likely explains why they are such a unique outlier in the Turkish data”



Social Domain Theory





Universal Norm Psychology

One of the most **central** social conventional considerations is **cultural** norms and values



Cultural knowledge important and adaptive to human learning
& **children** pick up on it **early in life**



Children **everywhere** share the same **predisposition** to acquire cultural knowledge – but learn the norms and values of their **specific** culture/community

Contact with animals (direct and indirect), culturally specific assumptions about animals

